

Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System (WHMIS)

WHMIS: Safety Data Sheet (SDS)

If you work in an organization that's regulated by WHMIS laws—that is, the Workplace Hazardous Materials Information System—you're also under rules from the GHS. This is the Globally Harmonized System of Classification and Labelling of Chemicals. You might work around hazardous substances and you need to understand the regulations your organization has on labeling those chemicals. Your health, safety, and wellbeing are a priority. So, let's get right into it.

This lesson covers the WHMIS 2015 supplier requirements under federal legislation—the Hazardous Products Act and the Hazardous Products Regulations, or HPR. Health Canada is the government body responsible for the overall WHMIS supplier-related laws. It is to be noted that WHMIS is also regulated in the workplace by the provincial, territorial, and federal (for federally regulated workplaces) governments through their occupational health and safety legislation. While these jurisdictions mostly based their WHMIS regulations on a common model, small variations between jurisdictions may exist regarding WHMIS 2015.

Suppliers and employers must use and follow the WHMIS 2015 requirements for labels and safety data sheets, also called SDSs, for hazardous products sold, distributed, or imported in Canada.

There are helpful references for the specifics of what should be included for pictograms and labels. But first, here's what you need to know regarding safety data sheets and their related requirements applicable to your organization.

An SDS is a summary document that provides information about the hazards of a product and advice about safety precautions. It's usually written by the manufacturer or supplier of the product. But in some circumstances, an employer may be required to prepare one, such as when the product is produced and used exclusively in that workplace.

Along with the basic information that a label provides, SDSs are an important resource when it comes to learning more about the products you're using. You should use this information to identify the hazards of any products you might be exposed to and protect yourself from those hazards. This includes safe handling and emergency measures.

You can think of the SDS as having four main purposes. They're required to provide information on:

One, Identification: for the product and supplier.

Two, Hazards: physical, such as fire hazards or reactivity to other substances and threats to human health.

Three, Prevention: steps you can take to work safely, reduce or prevent exposure, or in an emergency.

Four, Response: appropriate responses in various situations, such as first aid, fire, and accidental release.

So, after reading an SDS, the user should be informed on what the hazards of the product are, how to use the product safely, what to expect if the recommendations aren't followed, how to recognize symptoms of exposure, and what to do in the case of an emergency.

At this point, you may be wondering, should my workplace have safety data sheets?

If your workplace involves hazardous products, it's governed by the Hazardous Products Act. So, substances must meet certain criteria to be included in a hazard class or category. The official definition of a "hazardous product" is "product, mixture, material, or substance that is classified in accordance with the regulations made under subsection 15(1) in a category or subcategory of a hazard class listed in Schedule 2; (produit dangereux)."

In other words, every product that is classified as a "hazardous product" under WHMIS and that is intended for use, handling, or storage in a workplace in Canada is required to have an SDS.

The information elements provided on a safety data sheet must be in both official languages of Canada, English and French. In situations where there are separate SDSs in each language, both the English and French parts must be provided to the purchaser at the same time. Providing an SDS in only English or French is not in compliance with applicable laws.

Now, let's address what information should be included on the SDS.

The HPR specifies the sections and content required for the safety data sheet. See the materials or the WHMIS website for a full list of the section and heading requirements with mandatory information elements.

If you're the one creating the SDS, consult the most updated requirements from WHMIS and Health Canada. And if you're an employee, make sure that you're protecting yourself from any potential hazards. This includes being educated about the substances you're coming into contact with during your daily activities.

How can a supplier provide the SDS to its customers?

A supplier can provide both English and French versions to the purchaser of the hazardous product either in hard copy, such as by mail, or by electronic means, such as email. If the English and French versions of the SDS are in two separate parts, both versions must be attached to the same email or located in the same online folder.

Now, you should note—it is not acceptable to provide an SDS by simply giving the purchaser of the hazardous product a website address or hyperlink from which the purchaser may download the SDS for the hazardous product that they purchased.

**So, in order to remain up to date on hazardous materials, you need to know:
When is the SDS updated?**

First, they're required to be accurate at the time of sale. This means an SDS must be updated when the supplier becomes aware of any "significant new data". Basically, when new information arises that changes how the hazardous product is classified, or when there are changes to the way the product must be handled or stored for safety purposes, the SDS of the hazardous product must be updated. Or, if the directions to protect against the hazardous product change, then they're required to update all clients.

Safety data sheets must be updated within 90 days of the supplier being aware of the new information. The sheet must be accurate at the time of every sale or importation of the hazardous product. Suppliers have an ongoing responsibility to make sure safety data sheets and labels are accurate and compliant. Also, keep in mind that the requirements related to maintaining updated SDSs in the workplace may also be enforced in your jurisdiction. Check with your jurisdiction for more information.

You may be wondering, how will I know if an SDS has been updated?

Every SDS must provide a date of last revision in Section 16—Other Information. You will know if an SDS has been updated by checking this date and comparing it to the one on any previous SDS you have. Remember that there is no requirement for the supplier to provide an updated SDS to past purchasers of a hazardous product. Nevertheless, it is considered good practice to provide this information to purchasers who may still be using the product.

If you're an employer or a person in charge of implementing WHMIS practices, you have requirements for SDSs.

All hazardous products must have an updated SDS when they enter the workplace. They must be readily available to all workers exposed to the hazardous product, and to the health and safety committee or representative.

Employers may make the SDS information available on a digital device, as long as: all employees have access to it and are trained on how to use the computer or device, it is kept in working order, and, upon request, the

employer makes a hard copy of the SDS available to the employee or health and safety committee or representative.

As mentioned, an employer may be required to prepare an SDS in cases where the product is exclusively produced and used in the workplace.

Now , if you've ever looked at an SDS, you may have noticed that it's not always easy to understand. This is because the SDS is addressed to a variety of different audiences including occupational hygienists and safety professionals, employers, supervisors, emergency responders, and manufacturing workers. To help users quickly find the information they need, it's separated into sections by the various users it's directed to. Having a set format will make it easier to find the information you need on any SDS.

Now, all the information you need to know about a hazardous product may not necessarily be on the SDS. A lot of health hazard information, for example, is written in general terms. In addition, SDSs are often written to address many different uses or applications of the product, and the handling and safety precautions may not be specific to your workplace. Your workplace should have resources available to help you find more information if needed.

When you see "Not applicable" on sheets, it generally means that the info isn't relevant. For example, if the product is odourless, then the odour threshold would be reported as "Not applicable".

"Not available" generally indicates that the information could not be located or doesn't exist. For example, if the supplier can't locate any studies that measure the odour threshold, which is reported in Section 9 of the SDS, the supplier would report it as "Not available".

And the supplier should not use the abbreviation "n.a." or "NA" without defining it, as it could be construed to mean "not applicable" or "not available" or something entirely different. Clarity is key in order to ensure the safety of users.

As a worker, when would you use an SDS?

Always be familiar with the hazards of a product before you start using it. You should look at an SDS, match the name of the product on the container to the one on the SDS, know the hazards, understand safe handling and storage instructions, as well as understand what to do in case of an emergency. ///

Finally, what do these rules mean to you?

Well, to protect your health, make sure that the product is being used in the way the manufacturer intended; otherwise the advice provided on the SDS and label may not even apply. Or, the suggested protective measures listed may not be adequate .

Whatever your role, when it comes to hazardous products in the workplace, you need to know three things:

- **One, what are the hazards related to the product?**
- **Two, what precautions should I take?**
- **Three, how should I best respond in case of an emergency?**

As you answer these, keep in mind that SDSs may include general advice on potential hazards, but not specific to your workplace. For example, the SDS may indicate that a respirator is needed, but fail to specify which type of respirator. You can always get more information by asking your supervisor. These decisions may require the help of a safety professional or someone with chemical safety knowledge.

Now, this lesson is meant to educate you on the requirements of safety data sheets in your workplace. Check out those documents to make sure you're protected from any risk of exposure to hazardous products in your workplace.